UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

TOPIC 5: COVER AND THANK YOU LETTERS

Lesson 1: Cover Letter

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand the meaning and contents of a cover letter

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Create a sample cover letter for their Student Career Portfolio
- Be familiar with using a business letter format for professional communications

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will understand the meaning and purpose of a cover letter and it contents.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Handouts: **"Why Write a Cover Letter?"** and **"Writing a Cover Letter"**

Explain to students that "business letters" are the way to professionally communicate with potential employers. Hand out **"Why Write a Cover Letter?"** and **"Writing a Cover Letter"** sheets. Explain that the cover letter is an introduction of themselves and their skills, and is often read before the resume. If the cover letter is not informative and well-organized, the employer may not read the resume. Therefore, stress the importance of getting across ***why*** the employer would want to hire ***you*** in particular in a cover letter.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objective: Students will work on the format and components of a cover letter and practice receiving constructive feedback on written work.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Handouts: **"Cover Letter Format Guidelines"** and **"Sample Cover Letter,"** blank sheets of paper, pens/pencils

Ask students to look over their completed resume to review their skills and experience. Ask students to choose the job position they used for their mock interview or another advertised position, and ask them to prepare a hand-written cover letter for the position. Give out **"Cover Letter Format Guidelines"** and **"Sample Cover Letter"** handouts for the students to use as guides. When they are done, students can proofread their work, and have the Instructor read over it too. Remind students to be fair and constructive in their edits of themselves.

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objective: Students will create a professional cover letter.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection, index cards with **Mass CIS** log-in names and passwords, students' written drafts of their cover letters

Ask students to log-in to **Mass CIS (www.masscis.intocareers.org).** Under the **"Job Search"** section, ask students to select the **"Write a cover letter for your resume"** link, and follow the prompts. Remind them to write it with a particular job in mind (maybe the job they were using as their example for interviews), using their handwritten draft as a guide, and referencing relevant skills and experience for the position. Ask students to print out their completed cover letters for their Student Career Portfolio, and save a copy to their electronic portfolio.

Why Write A Cover Letter?

It's one of the most important tools when looking for a job.

Demonstrates that you can organize your thoughts and express yourself *(that your letter makes sense, and has a beginning, middle, and end)*

States what your experience and qualifications are *(briefly, the resume will be more detailed)*

Exhibits your level of professionalism *(following the standard business letter format, using appropriate language, etc.)*

Provides clues to your personality *("what type of an employee will this person be?")*

Displays how oriented you are to detail *(like correcting typos and spelling mistakes, getting names and addresses correct on the letters, etc.)*

Adapted from Youth Opportunities Unlimited

Writing a Cover Letter

A cover letter is a letter that job seekers send along with a resume. It is also called an "application letter." The cover letter goes in front of the resume. This letter has several functions:

It tells what position you are applying for

It summarizes why you are a strong candidate for the job

It requests an interview for the position you're applying for

It tells the employer how to contact you if he/she wants to schedule an interview

It thanks the employer for considering you for the job

Top 5 things to remember about cover letters

1. Your cover letter may be the FIRST IMPRESSION you make on the employer, so it's important that the letter is:

   Neat (typed or printed from a computer)

   PROFESSIONAL

   GRAMMATICALLY CORRECT, and

   FREE OF TYPOS and SPELLING ERRORS (have someone you trust proofread your letters — such as a parent, a friend, a mentor, a Job Corps counselor, etc.)

2. If Possible, the cover letter should be addressed to a specific person — "Dear Mr. (last name):" or "Dear Ms. (last name):." Since this is a formal business letter, you should not address the person by his/her first name. If you do not know the name of the person who will be reviewing the resumes, you have two choices:

   Call the organization to try to find out the person's name
   Address the letter to "Dear Sir or Madam:"

   The greeting should be followed by a colon (:).

3. The cover letter should be short and to-the-point. Generally, cover letters should be two to four paragraphs in length, but never longer than one page (front only).

4. In your cover letter, tell the employer what YOU can offer the ORGANIZATION (like skills, Dependability, commitment, and/or experience, etc.), not what the ORGANIZATION can offer YOU!

5. For the structure of the letter, follow a standard business letter. The guidelines and a sample cover Letter (see attached) will give you a good idea of how to set up the letter.

Cover Letter Format Guidelines

Your street address
Your city, state, and zip code

Today's date

Name of the person to whom you're writing (if it's available)
Job title of the person to whom you're writing (if it's available) Organization/Company name
Organization/Company street address
Organization/Company city, state, and zip code

Dear Mr. OR Ms. (last name):

Paragraph #1: Tell the employer which job you're applying for and how you found out about the job (i.e. the newspaper, career center, etc.)

Paragraph #2: State briefly why you're interested in the job. Also, if you know what the job requirements are, explain your qualifications for the job. Your qualifications might include your training at the site you are currently working at, Previous work experience, and/or other skills you have (like speaking a second language, etc.). Focus on how hiring you could benefit the organization — NOT how the organization can benefit you. Refer the employer to your resume for more details.

Paragraph #3: Request an interview and give the employer the information he/she, will need to reach you (i.e. phone number, e-mail address, pager number). Tell the employer that, you will follow up by phone if you do not hear from him/her within one week. Thank the employer for taking the time to consider you for the position.

Sincerely,

(Your handwritten signature)
Don't forget to sign the letter!

Your full name

Enclosure
Whenever you are including other documents with a business letter, write "Enclosure."

Adapted from Brockton Community Re-entry Center, Brockton, MA

Sample Cover Letter

184 Hathaway Street
Brockton, MA 02302

July 23, 2008

Josephine Allegra Employment
Specialist TNC Corporation
1269 City Line Road, Suite 221
Brockton, MA 02302

Dear Ms. Allegra:

Please accept this letter as an application for the open receptionist position at TNC Organization, which was advertised in the database at the Brockton Career Works one-stop career center.

The receptionist position interests me for several reasons. First, this position would enable me to use many of the office and computer skills I developed while training at the Job Corps Center in Grafton, Massachusetts. While at Job Corps, I gained knowledge in typing, telephone communication, customer service, and Microsoft Office. In addition, I have held several customer service positions and I enjoy this type of work. Please refer to my resume for more details about my skills and experience.

I would really appreciate an opportunity to meet with you in-person to further discuss my qualifications for the position. You may contact me during the day at (508) 922-7036 or anytime at christinag@aol.com. If I do not hear from you within the next week, I will call to follow up on my application. Thank you for your consideration, and I hope to hear from you soon regarding the open receptionist position.

Sincerely,

(Your handwritten signature)
Don't forget to sign the letter!

Christina Gifford

Enclosure

Adapted from Brockton Community Re-entry Center, Brockton, MA

Lesson 2: Thank You Letter

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand the meaning and contents of a post-interview thank you letter

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Create a sample thank you letter for their Student Career Portfolio
- Be familiar with using a business letter format for professional communications

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students understand the meaning and use of a post-interview thank you letter.

Time: 10 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Why Send a Thank You Letter?"**

Remind students that "business letters" are the way to professionally communicate with potential employers. Hand out **"Why Send a Thank You Letter"** and have students read the list aloud. Explain that thank you letters after interviews aren't necessarily expected, but are a good "extra" to show your interest in the job and appreciation for being considered.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objective: Students will create a thank you letter and practice giving and receiving constructive feedback on written work.

Time: 25 minutes

Materials: Handouts: **"Thank You Letter Tips"** and **"Sample Thank You Letter,"** blank sheets of paper, pens/pencils

Have students use their mock interview as a basis for their thank you Letter. Give students **"Thank You Letter Tips"** and **"Sample Thank You Letter"** sheets as guides. Ask them to hand-write a draft, while trying to keep to the business letter format. When they are done, students can proofread each other's work before they are typed up. Remind students to be balanced and constructive in their feedback of others' letters.

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objective: Students will use a word processing program and information from personal resumes to create a professional post-interview thank you letter.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Computers with Microsoft Word

Ask students to use the computer to type their thank you letter in Microsoft Word, using a "thank you for interview" or "business letter" template (which can be chosen from file, then new, then type "thank you for interview" or "business template" into the menu). Ask students to print the letter for their Student Career Portfolio and save it into their electronic portfolio.

Finishing Touch — Writing A "Thank You" Letter

Taking the time to write a thank you note after every interview you have could set you apart — in a positive way — from other people who have applied for the same position!

Thank You Letter...

- Demonstrates to the employer that you are genuinely interested in the position for which you've interviewed. *The interviewer knows that your time is valuable and that it takes time and effort to construct a well-written thank you letter.*
- Shows that you have good "follow-through." *In other words, it gives the interviewer the impression that you are committed to "finishing what you start."*
- Demonstrates that you're willing to work. *Although everyone should write a thank you letter after they interview for a job, many people don't. Writing a thank you letter to a prospective employer shows that you're willing to "go the extra mile."*
- Allows you to "sell yourself" one last time before the interviewer makes a hiring decision. *In a thank you letter, you have an opportunity to tell the interviewer again why you're the person for the job.*
- Makes the interviewer feel special. *Everyone likes to be thanked. While helping the interviewer feeling good about himself or herself is not the point of the thank you letter, making the interviewer fee! special is likely to encourage him or her to have positive feelings about you.*

Should I send a typed or hand-written letter?

For the most part, this decision is up to you. The most important thing is that you thank the interviewer in writing, so choose one of the two. The "safest" approach is to type a thank you letter, in the format of a business letter. This option is considered more "safe" because a potential employer might view a handwritten thank you note as too casual.

Some things to consider when deciding whether to send a handwritten or typed letter:

- What type of job did you interview for? *If the job is in a business setting (such as an accounting clerk), it may be more appropriate to send the interviewer a typed thank you letter. If the job is in a more casual setting (such as a store or in a non-traditional field), you might opt to handwrite the thank you note.*
- Do you have neat handwriting? *If you have terrible handwriting, no matter what job you're interviewing for, you should type a thank you letter.*
- What type of interview did you have? *Did you feel like you "connected" to the interviewer? Did the interview have a casual tone? If you felt very comfortable with the interviewer, a handwritten thank you note might add a nice personal touch. If you felt some distance between the interviewer and you, or if you thought that the interview was formal, a typed thank you letter is probably a better choice.*

Adapted from Brockton Community Re-entry Center, Brockton, MA

Important "Thank You" Tips

Regardless of which type of thank you letter you write, you should send the letter within three days of the interview, but preferably the day of the interview. You never know when the interviewer is going to make a hiring decision, so you should send the thank you letter as soon as possible.

Make sure you spell the interviewer's name correctly and, if you use the interviewer's job title in your letter, make sure his or her title is correct.

In the thank you letter, try to mention something you discussed during your interview. This might be a specific aspect of the job that you think you would really enjoy or be good at (and why) or job experience/training you've had that relates closely to the job.

The thank you letter is also an opportunity to discuss skills you may have that are related to the job but that you did not have a chance to discuss during the interview.

Just like with the cover letter, the thank you letter should be short and to-the-point — no longer than three paragraphs.

Carefully *proofread* every thank you letter. After you've carefully proofread the letter, have someone you trust carefully proofread the letter. If the job requires someone who is detail-oriented and you have typos, spelling errors, or grammatical errors in your thank you letter, the interviewer may think you're not the best candidate for the job.

If you do choose to send a handwritten thank you note, select a plain style note card for your note — nothing too fancy or decorative.

Please see thank you letter sample on the next page

Adapted from Brockton Community Re-entry Center, Brockton, MA

Sample Thank You Letter

Terri S. Jones
109 Brick Road
Boston, MA 02122

May 31, 2000

Delia Correale
Administrative Manager
All-Star Graphics, Inc.
24 Westgate Drive, Suite 307
Boston, MA 02215

Dear Ms. Correale:

Thank you for taking time out of your schedule today to talk with me about the Accounting Clerk position. I was impressed with the company, and after our discussion about the job responsibilities, I am excited about the prospect of working for All-Star Graphics.

During our interview, it became clear that you are seeking an Accounting Clerk with strong computer skills and math abilities. I feel that my Job Corps training has prepared me well for this position. At Job Corps. I studied Excel and Microsoft Word for over six months. In addition, my experience as a cashier at Stop & Shop helped me to develop and use my math skills and customer sendee skills.

I look forward to hearing from you soon. Please feel free to contact me by phone at (617) 399-4387 or by e-mail at teiTii@aol.com if I can provide any further information. Thank you again for your time and consideration.

Sincerely,

(Your handwritten signature)
Don't forget to sign the letter!

Terri S. Jones